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The Palatine Paradoxographer and the Roman Tradition of Marvels

eul_aid: npc

Period: *Ῥωμαϊκή* [Roman](#)
Dialect: *Μικταὶ διάλεκτοι* [Mixed Dialects](#)
Domain: *Ἱστορία* [History](#)
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The Palatine Paradoxographer is the name given to an anonymous Greek author from the Roman imperial period, likely active in the 1st or 2nd century CE. This figure was a compiler working in the tradition of paradoxography, a popular genre that collected strange and wondrous facts about the natural world, distant lands, and history.

The author's sole surviving work is a collection of 49 short entries, preserved in a single 10th-century manuscript. It describes marvels such as unusual biological phenomena, exotic customs, and remarkable events. According to modern scholars, the text is a compilation drawn from earlier, often lost, Hellenistic sources.

Its significance lies in providing a clear example of how paradoxography worked, excerpting curiosities from authoritative texts for a Roman audience fascinated by the exotic. Academics also value the collection because it explicitly cites several lost authors, including the historian Theopompus and the poet-scholar Callimachus, thereby preserving fragments of their work. The text offers a window into the kinds of knowledge and entertainment that circulated in the ancient world.

Works (1)

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